FASHION
PROFILE

"I just have to pick up Jack at four." His 12-year-old is at school in west London. Ford has been a single parent since his husband, the former fashion journalist Richard Buckley, died three years ago, after suffering complications related to a throat cancer diagnosis 30 years earlier, while they were living in Los Angeles.

First, I have to wonder: as a life-long Democrat—ever prescient of coming trends—has Ford hedged against a second Trump presidency by moving to London? Recent press reports made it seem as if he has just relocated here. He has bought a Chelsea house with a whopping £80 million price tag that has set estate agents all a-gossip; they're betting on a wealthy American refugee influx.

He sets me straight. Being here has less to do with politics, he insists, than being an anglophile, how he wants to bring up Jack and his long history in London. "Do you know, I've lived here longer than in any other city in my entire life. Twenty-five years. I moved the Gucci design studio to Grafton Street in London in the mid-1990s." He set up the Tom Ford studio in Victoria as well. That was a feather in the cap of London as a creative fashion hub. "I always intended to raise Jack in the UK. He was indeed raised here until he was five. We moved to LA to be near Richard's doctors. This will sound quaint," he adds, "but I love London. It has all the same cultural advantages of New York City, if not more. It's calm, peaceful, there's more green. It's civilised and I love English humour."

Happily, Jack seems to be thriving. "I think the education system is perhaps more old-fashioned here in some ways, but I also feel that it's more complete, and that a scholastic work ethic and manners are still incredibly important. While I love Los Angeles, I think it's a place to live when one is an adult." It was great for his boy to enjoy a year-round outdoor life of swimming, football and tennis, but "the extremely materialistic and status-conscious culture and lack of old-fashioned manners was starting to influence his behaviour and values. I can see a tremendous change in him since he has been back in a London school."

Part of the reason Ford can comfortably afford the Chelsea house is that Estée Lauder bought Tom Ford, the eponymous brand he set up in 2006, for $2.8



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